MIR SPACE STATION

"Mir" in Russian means both "peace" and "world." The space station of that name launched in 1986 was designed with six docking ports, which could be used to attach special modules for scientific research.

Strategic Defense Initiative that would put weapons in space, but also announced in 1984 that the United States would have a permanently manned space station in orbit within a decade.

This was, of course, moving into territory already solidly occupied by the Soviet Union. The Soviet space station program had continued to progress through the 1980s – during the post-*Challenger* interruption of the Shuttle program cosmonauts were the only people traveling into space. In February 1986 Salyut 7 was joined in orbit by a third generation orbital station, Mir. Once Mir was occupied, the aging Salyut was left to fly on unmanned until 1991.

Mir was a considerable step forward from the Salyuts. The key improvement was Mir's design as a modular station, with more comfortable living conditions and more sophisticated on-board life-support systems, and the practicality of being able to attach extra modules to the original core. Additional modules sent up to dock with Mir included an astrophysics observatory and laboratories for research in zero-gravity, metallurgy, and crystallography.

The Soviets also had a much improved manned spacecraft to service Mir, the Soyuz-TM. In response to the Americans' Space Shuttle program, the Soviets began building the Shuttle Buran in 1980. However, the Buran only made one unmanned flight – lifted into space by the powerful Energyia liquid-hydrogen booster introduced in 1988 – before it was canceled due

SHUTTLE DOCKING

The Shuttle Atlantis, *docked with the Mir space station, is photographed from a Russian Soyuz-TM space craft in 1995. The Shuttle missions to Mir were a preparation for collaboration on the International Space Station.*

SPACE COOPERATION

A badge celebrates cooperation in space between America and Russia in the post-Soviet era.